

dynasty—founded by Kublai Khan, the Mongol conqueror of China—the country's rulers since 1279. Zhu reigned as emperor Hongwu ("Vastly Martial"—a reference to his military prowess) from 1368 until his death in 1398, by which time he had firmly established one of China's most influential, but also most authoritarian, dynasties. He and his successors brought three centuries of prosperity and stability to the country, establishing its government and bureaucracy in a form that would endure, with slight modifications, until the demise of the imperial system in 1911, and broadening the base of its economy.

Driving out the Mongols

Zhu's new dynasty arose from the chaos that accompanied the decline of the Yuan. In the 1340s and '50s, factionalism in the Mongol court, rampant government corruption, and a series of natural disasters, including plagues and epidemics, resulted in wholesale breakdown in law and order and administration as peasant groups rose up against their faltering foreign overlords. Zhu himself lost most of his family in an outbreak of plague in 1344, and after a few years spent as a mendicant monk, begging for food, he joined the Red Turbans, one of a constellation of native Han Chinese peasant secret societies in rebellion against the Yuan. Determined, ruthless, and an able general, the young rebel climbed the ranks to the leadership of the Red Turbans, and later overcame his rivals to become the national leader against the Yuan.

Zhu took control of much of southern and northern China and declared himself emperor before pushing the Mongols out of their capital at Dadu (Beijing) in 1368. The rest of the country was then subdued, although the Mongols resisted in the far north until the early 1370s, and the unification of China was not achieved until the defeat of the last Mongol forces in the south in 1382.

Reform and despotism

Zhu's first priority as emperor Hongwu was to establish order—decades of conflict had ravaged China and impoverished its rural population. His humble beginnings may



The tribulations of Hongwu's early life led him to improve the lot of China's rural poor, but they also created a cruel and irrational man who murdered all those he suspected of disloyalty.

have influenced some of his early policies: responsibility for tax assessment was entrusted to rural communities, sweeping away the problem of rapacious tax collectors who had preyed on poorer areas; slavery was abolished; many large estates were confiscated; and lands owned by the state in the under-populated north of the country were handed to landless peasants, to encourage them to settle there.

From 1380, Hongwu instituted government reforms that gave him personal control over all matters of state. After executing his prime minister, who had been implicated in a plot to overthrow him, he abolished the prime ministership and the central secretariat and had the heads of the next layer of government, the six ministries, report directly to him, ensuring he oversaw even minor decisions.

From then on, Hongwu acted as his own prime minister. His workload was almost unbearable—in a single week-long stint, he had to scrutinize and approve some 1,600 documents—and as a result, the state became incapable of responding swiftly to crises. Although in time a new grand secretariat emerged—an advisory board through which the emperor responded »